

Knowledge Content Style Guide

Support

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We at Delphix embrace Knowledge Centered Support (KCS) as it empowers the customer to be self-sufficient and allows us, Support, to focus on the most difficult issues.

7 Knowledge-Centered Support (KCS) Guiding Principles

- Process
 - Workflow encompasses knowledge creation, use, and improvement
- Culture
 - Knowledge sharing
 - Teamwork and collaboration
 - Collective ownership of the knowledge base
- Quality
 - Framework to ensure consistency and quality
 - Documents are findable, usable and relevant
- Technology
 - Tools provide an accessible, shareable environment and support knowledge processes
- Content
 - Collection of captured experiences
 - Sufficient to solve, keep it simple

7.1 KCS Concepts

- Knowledge content is written from the author's personal experience.
- It doesn't have to be perfect to be valuable.
- It is not intended to replace product documentation.
- It should not duplicate other available content.
- Multiple users may easily consume it many times (link it to the case).
- Using is a review, meaning there is an opportunity to improve the content with each use.

8 Style Guide Purpose

The purpose of this style guide is help ensure that our Support Engineers have the tools to produce excellent content with a common look and feel.

Consult [The Delphix Writing Style Guide](#) for further detail and clarification.

8.1 Global Writing

- Write for the broadest possible audience.
- Use examples that have meaning across many cultures.
- Avoid using slang words and phrases, local events or references.

8.2 Title Guidelines

- Start title with Knowledge Base Article number or Technical Bulletin number (KBAxxxx or TBxxx)
- The title should be short, but as unique and descriptive as possible.
- The title is a big factor in determining whether the knowledge document will be found, add keywords to the title.
- Format
 - Use initial capital letters for words in the title
 - Articles such as *a*, *an*, *the*, *and* are lower case
 - Do not include ending punctuation
 - The format is similar to a book title
- Include Release or Version Information when relevant to the content.
- Avoid titles such as 'Problem with...', 'Unable to...', "... Does Not Work" - Be Specific!
- Don't use parentheses () as they do not work well with Zendesk

8.3 Active Voice

- Use active voice making the person or item performing the action the subject of the sentence.
- Write articles as though you were speaking to a friend.
 - You want the reader to feel comfortable with the instructions.
- Active voice lets the reader answer the following questions quickly and easily:
 - What is happening?
 - Who is performing the action?
 - What, if anything, do I need to do now?
- Here are some possible active subjects of a sentence:
 - The name of the product ("Delphix Self-Service manages . . .")

- The name of a part of the product ("The HostChecker confirms the . . .")
- The System Administrator, Network Administrator, Storage Administrator, etc.
- You
- Avoid using personal preferences when writing a set of how-to steps.
 - "I's" should not be used

8.4 Neutral Tone

- Use a neutral, adult-to-adult tone; avoid patronizing expressions.
- Avoid any expressions that would offend the reader.
- Do not use humor. What may be humorous to you may not be humorous to someone else.
- Use who or whom to refer to people.
- Do not use she, he, him or her. Rewrite the sentence to use a neutral subject, such as developer, user, administrator, etc.
- Do not presume that a task is easy for your reader. Avoid words such as simply, easy, and just.

8.5 Contractions

- Do not use contractions.
- Contractions are not easily understood nor easily translated.

8.6 Acronyms and Abbreviations

- Acronyms and abbreviations, especially in technical documentation, are accepted and generally understood.
- The first usage of an acronym within the document should be followed by the complete word or phrase in parentheses.
 - For example, the steps below must be used to enable the SDD (Select Data Distribution) feature.
- Avoid using *e.g.* and *i.e.*, use the full English phrases "For example" and "In other words".

8.7 Sentence Structure

- Use complete sentences that begin with an uppercase character and end with final punctuation.
- Do not use symbols, such as an ampersand (&), equal sign (=), instead of words in text. Symbols can present problems for international audiences.
- Place code examples at the end of a sentence. Do not break a sentence in the middle to include a code example.
- Use positive sentences to avoid confusion. Negative sentences can interfere with quick, accurate reader comprehension.

- Use strong sentences, which means use the subject-verb-object order. This practice makes reading easier and comprehension faster for both native and non-native English speakers.
- Use short sentences whenever possible. As a guideline, limit sentences to 25 words or fewer. To shorten a sentence that seems too long and complex, break it into two sentences and repeat the subject at the beginning of the second sentence.
- Rewrite sentences that use phrases made up of a word that begins or ends in *-ing* and is followed by a noun. This composition can be ambiguous because readers might interpret the *-ing* word as being an adjective, a verb, or a noun.

Correct	Incorrect
<i>This tool is used to run reports.</i>	<i>This tool is used for running reports.</i>
<i>One way to avoid last-minute release delays is by addressing issues early.</i>	<i>Addressing issues early avoids last-minute release delays.</i>

- Avoid the ambiguous use of a pronoun to refer to a previous noun, phrase, or clause. Pronouns that typically cause confusion are *it*, *they*, *them*, *its*, and *their*.

Correct	Incorrect
<i>You can change the configuration file that is generated by the server installation after the file is created.</i>	<i>You can change the configuration file that is generated by the server installation after it is created.</i>

- Use the terms *this*, *that*, *these*, and *those* as adjectives followed by nouns. To avoid possible ambiguous references, do not use these terms as pronouns.

Correct	Incorrect
<i>The procedure contains required steps and optional steps. Steps marked optional can be performed after the installation of the Delphix Engine.</i>	<i>The procedure steps are divided into required and optional steps. Those marked optional can be performed after the installation of the Delphix Engine.</i>

8.8 Formatting

- Do not use Italic and underline
- Boldface is used to indicate interface elements
 - **Enter**, when referring to text field selection
 - **Select**, when referring menu selection
 - **Click**, when referring to button or tab selections
- Monospace: Words enclosed in double curly braces `{{ }}`
 - Used to indicate system messages, CLI commands, file names, file paths and system directories, user input, and anything that is not an interface element.

- Code blocks: Use code block to properly frame the code

8.9 Text Links

- Link to critical information that is too lengthy to include in the text.
- Use the toolbar to link another document title or section.
 - This knowledge article may be of interest: **Managing Delphix Storage**.
 - See the documented fix in the Microsoft Knowledge Base article **How to Make Your Widget Work**.

8.10 Screenshots

- Use screenshots as a supplement to steps, not as a substitute for steps.
- Use screenshots to demonstrate difficult concepts, to show complex relationships that may be difficult to describe with just text, or to guide readers to the part of a screen that they need to use, such as a particular field.

8.11 Short Paragraphs

- As a guideline, limit paragraph size to three to six sentences.
- If a paragraph exceeds six sentences, then ensure that all the material relates directly to the topic of the paragraph.

8.12 Consistency

- Consistency is extremely important in technical writing.
- Be consistent with terms and expressions throughout your document to avoid confusion and misunderstanding.
 - For example, if your documentation refers to *Delphix Self-Service* in one paragraph, then it must not refer to the *Delphix Self-Service utility* elsewhere, or readers will be looking for two separate interfaces.
- Be particularly careful about the consistent use of product names, including capitalization, spelling, and spaces within a name.

8.13 Proper Use of Words and Phrases

- The concisely written material is easier to read than verbose material and readers can get the pertinent information quickly.
 - Omit unnecessary words.
- Avoid the temptation to use slang, newly invented (marketing speak), or erroneously used words or phrases.
- Avoid creating verbs, for example by arbitrarily adding suffixes such as *-ize* to nouns or by using an adjective such as *obsolete* as a verb.

8.14 Clearly Defined Terminology

- Define new terms within the document either in a footnote or within the paragraph body.

8.15 Editorial Review Checklist

•	Document	Duplicates	Are there duplicate KBAs in the knowledge base? Duplicate documents should have been found during the search process. Existing content should have been fixed or flagged, rather than creating a new document.
•		Easy to Find	Perform a search (post publish) based on the customer context to ensure the document is findable. The document should show high in the search results. Are there improvements that could be made to the document to improve findability? - Update title, add tags.
•	Content	Title	Does the title describe the issue or question? Is the title as unique and descriptive as possible? Is title formatting correct? Does the title contain the KBA ID? Be sure to add the ID to the KBA ID spreadsheet.
•		Style	Content flows well, easy to read, contains essential parts to address issue or question (not too verbose), used complete thoughts. Omitted references to I, we, to customer, systems, IP addresses, etc. No slang or local references used. Did not use uncommon acronyms and spelled out the words to avoid any confusion. Internal references or proprietary information is hidden. Code blocks used correctly. Used consistent font.
•		Spelling	Check spelling, punctuation and grammar. While the KBA does not need to be perfect, the article must be clear and easy to understand.
•		Links/URLs	External links/URLs are available to customers?

			<i>Internal links/URLs not revealed externally/flagged as Internal Only?</i> <i>Do links go to the correct title/content?</i> <i>Are inline links being used correctly?</i> <i>Is hyperlink format correct?</i>
•		<i>Keywords</i>	<i>Do the keywords fit with the content and problem/situation context? Are the keywords appropriate for intent-based search?</i> <i>(Appropriate within title and article tags)</i>
•		<i>Error Codes</i>	<i>Are Error Codes being used correctly?</i>
•	<i>Attributes</i>	<i>Distribution</i>	<i>Is there a really good reason why the KBA should not be EXTERNAL?</i> <i>Is Internal Only information hidden from external view?</i>
•		<i>Category</i>	<i>Is the correct category (Administration, MSSQL Server, Oracle, Other Database, Platforms, Replication, Sys Admin, DxOS) selected?</i>
•		<i>Comments</i>	<i>Have all open comments been processed?</i>